

KEY BATTLE

BATTLE OF
POITIERS (TOURS)
732CE

An army of Arab and Berber horsemen from Spain – an area recently conquered by the Muslims – invaded Frankish territory in 732CE. Charles Martel, leader of the Franks, confronted them between Tours and Poitiers. The Frankish warriors fought dismounted in a tightly-packed square, and held off the Muslims with sword, spear, and shield to win a famous defensive victory.



▲ Charles Martel rides a white horse in this fanciful 19th-century painting of a battle said to have saved Christendom from Muslim domination.

▼ VIKING SWORD

The seafaring Scandinavians known as Norsemen, or Vikings, were well-armed with swords, axes, shields, spears, javelins, and bows; some also wore mail armour. Some of their swords were pattern-welded for extra strength.



KEY DEVELOPMENT

THE WEAPONS OF EARLY
MEDIEVAL EUROPE

From 500CE to 1000, the relatively weak states of western Europe were prey for raiders. By the 11th century, however, the improved use of armoured cavalry in mounted combat was becoming a significant factor on the battlefield.

The fall of the Roman Empire in western Europe, in the 5th century CE, was followed by a general decline in political organization and technology. This was not true, however, of the Byzantine Empire, the successor to the Roman Empire in the east. Despite many setbacks, the Byzantine imperial system retained its resources and organization to field an impressive army, centred around heavily armoured cavalry, known as cataphracts. The empire also maintained a formidable navy, and even devised an advanced secret weapon: the flammable liquid known as Greek fire – a predecessor of napalm. Byzantine ships used pump-operated tubes in their prows to spray streams of flames at enemy vessels.

A CITIZEN MILITIA

Post-Roman western Europe, meanwhile, fell short of Byzantine sophistication. Even the kingdom of the Franks, the most prosperous successor state to the empire, at first had only a tribal warband for an army. By 800CE, under Charlemagne, the Franks ruled a large area of western Europe and, were bold enough to proclaim a Holy Roman Empire. However, they still lacked the resources to sustain permanent armed forces, instead depending on a system of obligation that required local lords, their followers, and levies (peasants and freemen) to turn up, fully equipped, for service. In Anglo-Saxon England, local lords or “thegns” assembled armed men from their districts as the “fyrd” – a part-time militia. Armed with swords, spears, and simple bows, and protected at best by mail armour, iron helmets, and shields, they were often unable to defend coasts or ill-defined land borders against a substantial hostile force.

THE RISE OF THE VIKINGS

The Scandinavian Vikings first appear in European chronicles as seaborne raiders in late 700CE, using their longships to carry out hit-and-run attacks on coastal targets, and penetrating far inland along rivers. Later they became settlers and conquerors, ruling over much of the British Isles and part of northern France. Countermeasures against Viking raids were limited: the Franks built fortified bridges to block rivers; the Irish built tall towers as lookout posts; and the Anglo-Saxons created a network of



fortified settlements – the “burhs”. In battle, however, Viking axes and swords were a match for any technology available to the settled kingdoms.

Throughout the 10th and 11th centuries, a fresh dynamism emerged in western European warfare. Hardened, quenched steel was increasingly used for swords, crossbows began to appear, and motte-and-bailey castles were built – still made